

Unstable Paths Home

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Research Questions:

How do race and placement instability shape reunification outcomes for children in foster care, and to what extent does placement instability act as an upstream factor that helps explain observed disparities? Additionally, do the same predictors meaningfully relate to the likelihood of re-entry?

Introduction:

The foster care system in the United States is intended to provide temporary protection for children experiencing abuse, neglect, or unsafe living conditions while working toward long-term permanency. Reunification with the biological family is often considered the preferred outcome because of the importance of maintaining family connections and minimizing long-term disruption. However, reunification outcomes are not experienced equally across all children in foster care. Many children experience repeated placement changes, extended time in care, and other forms of instability that may reduce the likelihood of successfully returning home. These differences raise broader sociological questions about how institutional systems, demographic characteristics, and placement instability shape outcomes for vulnerable children.

Using Adoption and Foster Care Analysis and Reporting System (AFCARS) administrative data from 2015 through 2024, this paper argues that reunification outcomes are shaped not only by individual child or family characteristics, but also by patterns of institutional instability within the foster care system itself. Specifically, repeated placement changes appear to substantially reduce the likelihood of reunification and may partially function as a mechanism through which broader disparities in foster care outcomes emerge.

Literature Review:

Reunification is generally considered the preferred permanency goal for children placed in foster care (Akin, 2011). Reunification reflects the hope that the conditions leading to removal have been addressed and that children can safely return to their biological families. However, the literature shows that reunification is not a simple successful endpoint. Some scholars have argued that permanency itself remains a source of weakness within the U.S. child welfare system, particularly when children continue to experience instability after exiting care (Ahn et al., 2025). Re-entry into foster care is especially important in this context because a return home does not necessarily mean that permanency has been achieved in a lasting or stable way. Kimberlin et al. (2009) argue that the harms associated with re-entry are serious enough that preventing re-entry “must be recognized as a fundamental responsibility of the child welfare system.” Therefore, reunification should be understood not only as whether a child exits foster care, but also as whether that exit reflects a stable and lasting permanency outcome.

Existing research shows that reunification is shaped by a wide range of child, family, case, and system-level factors (Sitjes-Figueras et al., 2025). These factors include race and ethnicity, parental challenges, placement conditions, agency practices, and geographic context. Some predictors may reflect case-level concerns related to child safety and family readiness. For example, parental substance abuse and mental health concerns have been linked to higher risk of re-entry after reunification (Font et al., 2018). However, other predictors raise broader sociological questions about inequality within the child welfare system. When reunification outcomes differ across race, geography, or placement experiences, those differences may reflect not only individual family circumstances, but also institutional processes that shape which families are able to move successfully through the system.

Reunification outcomes are not distributed evenly across racial and ethnic groups. Studies repeatedly find that racial and ethnic disparities persist within child welfare systems (LaBrenz et al., 2021; Sieger, 2020; Sitjes-Figueras et al., 2025). LaBrenz et al. (2021) found that disparities in reunification remained even after accounting for child and system-level factors. They also found that parents of color may have less access to services that support reunification, which can make it more difficult to satisfy case plan requirements and regain custody. Research also showed that among children removed for substance-related reasons, African American children were less likely to reunify than white children with similar case profiles (Sieger, 2020).

The literature does not suggest that racial disparities follow one simple or uniform pattern. Sitjes-Figueras et al. (2025) show that reunification is shaped by multiple overlapping factors, meaning that race must be interpreted alongside case conditions, placement experiences, and institutional context. This means that racial disparities in reunification may not operate directly or independently. Instead, race may be connected to other forms of instability within the system, including differences in placement disruption, service access, agency decision-making, or regional child welfare practices. Analysis of reunification should examine how racial differences may be connected to broader patterns of institutional instability.

Recent research also shows that broader geographic and institutional contexts shape foster care outcomes. Placement stability, measured by the number of placements a child experiences while in care, varies across county and state contexts (Heaton et al., 2025). Research found that higher-level social and geographic factors are connected to racial differences in placement stability, suggesting that placement disruption is not only an individual case outcome but also a system-level pattern. Agency practices also matter. Others found that children whose cases involved a family team decision meeting at removal had stronger reunification outcomes

(Ahn et al., 2025). This suggests that the way agencies involve families, coordinate services, and make decisions can affect whether reunification becomes possible. Because agency practices and child welfare policies vary across location, geographic context may help explain why reunification and stability differ across children and families.

Placement stability is especially important because it connects child welfare experiences to permanency outcomes. Placement instability is linked to harmful developmental and permanency consequences, and repeated moves can disrupt children's relationships, routines, schooling, and sense of security. Ahn et al. (2025) found that children with fewer placement changes were not only more likely to reunify, but also reunified more quickly. Similarly, Sitjes-Figueras et al. (2025) found that familial and placement stability are associated with higher odds of reunification. These findings suggest that placement stability may operate as more than a background characteristic. It may function as a pathway through which broader inequalities become connected to permanency outcomes. If children from some groups are more likely to experience repeated placement changes, and repeated placement changes reduce the likelihood of reunification, then placement stability may help explain part of the relationship between inequality and reunification.

The racial and relational context of placement may also matter. LaBrenz et al. (2022) found that racially matched foster placements were associated with greater placement stability. This shifts attention away from child race alone and toward the relationship between the child and foster placement environment. Although this research focuses primarily on placement stability rather than reunification itself, it supports the broader argument that placement experiences may shape later permanency outcomes. Who a child is placed with, how stable that

placement is, and how well the placement context supports continuity may all affect whether reunification becomes achievable.

Existing research identifies several major predictors of reunification, including race, parental barriers, case processes, placement stability, and geography. However, these factors are often studied separately rather than as part of the same process. The literature shows that race, placement stability, and re-entry matter. This literature suggests that placement stability should be understood not only as an outcome of foster care, but also as a possible mechanism connecting race, institutional context, and reunification outcomes.

Contribution:

This study uses ten years of AFCARS data to treat placement instability not as a background variable but as a mechanism connecting race and reunification outcomes. Methodologically, this study also contributes by using a decade of AFCARS administrative data, covering approximately 2.6 million children recorded in foster care cases across the United States. This broader scope allows the project to examine patterns across multiple years rather than relying on a single year or a narrower geographic sample. By connecting race, region, placement stability, reunification, and re-entry, this study offers a larger-scale view of how foster care processes shape permanency outcomes.

Methods and Data:

Data Source:

This study uses data from the Adoption and Foster Care Analysis and Reporting System, commonly referred to as AFCARS. AFCARS is a federally mandated administrative data system

that collects information on children in foster care in the United States. The data are distributed through the National Data Archive on Child Abuse and Neglect, which is funded by the Children's Bureau within the Administration for Children and Families. The AFCARS foster care file includes child-level information on demographics, race and ethnicity, removal reasons, placement settings, case goals, disability indicators, foster caretaker characteristics, discharge reasons, and dates related to foster care entry and exit. Their codebook identifies 106 variables in the distributed AFCARS foster care file(s).

The analysis uses AFCARS foster care data from 2015 through 2024. This ten-year period was selected because it provides a broad window for observing foster care entries, exits, placement histories, and re-entry patterns while keeping the data structure relatively consistent. One complication is that AFCARS reporting changed in recent years. It was not until fiscal year 2023 that all states were fully compliant with AFCARS 2020 format, so that format was made compatible with the older AFCARS 1993 structure where possible. Because of that translation process, some variables were unable to be analyzed.

Because AFCARS is an administrative data source, this project does not rely on a traditional survey sample. Instead, it uses records submitted by child welfare agencies. This gives the study broad coverage of foster care cases across the United States, but it also means the analysis depends on how consistently states recorded and reported information. The datasets are therefore useful for identifying large-scale patterns, but the results should be interpreted as observational associations rather than causal estimates.

Sample Construction:

The original data was stored as separate annual files. These files were imported into R, standardized, and combined into a long-format dataset. Each record was assigned a year based on the source file name, and records were classified by file type. State and FIPS information were also standardized where needed. The initial workflow read all available files, extracted the year from the file name, identified whether each file was an AB or base file (2020 vs 1993 format), and combined them into one long AFCARS file.

Because some children appeared more than once within the same year, the next step was to reduce duplicate child-year records. For base files, the latest record within each child-year was retained using reporting period dates when available. For AB files, the latest record was retained using reporting year and reporting month. When both AB and base records existed for the same child in the same year, the AB record was prioritized. This produced a cleaned child-year dataset with one record per child per year.

After duplicate reduction, the data were reshaped from long format to wide format using the child identifier, so that each child had one row and year-specific values were stored across separate columns. The wide file was then collapsed into a child-level analytic file. Some variables were retained using the most recent non-missing value, some were coded as “ever” indicators, some were summarized using maximum or mean values, and date variables were collapsed using earliest observed dates when appropriate. For example, stable demographic variables such as sex and race/ethnicity were treated as latest observed values, while removal reasons and disability indicators were treated as ever-observed indicators. Placement count was summarized using the maximum observed number of placement settings.

The final analytic dataset includes unique children observed in AFCARS between 2015 and 2024. The regression models use children with non-missing values on the outcome and included covariates. Descriptive summaries use all available cases for each variable, while model-based results are based on complete cases for the specific model being estimated.

Outcome Variables:

The primary outcome is reunification. Reunification was coded using the AFCARS discharge reason variable. In AFCARS, discharge reason records why a child exited foster care. Discharge reason includes reunification along with other discharge outcomes such as adoption, guardianship, emancipation, transfer to another agency, runaway, and death of the child.

For the main reunification analysis, reunification was coded as a binary outcome using the latest observed discharge reason retained in the child-level analytic file. Children were coded as reunified if their latest observed discharge reason was reunification with a parent or primary caretaker. Children whose latest observed discharge reason was another exit type were coded as not reunified. Children with missing discharge reason information were treated as missing rather than being counted as non-reunification. This coding choice means that the main analysis focuses on whether the child's latest observed foster care discharge outcome during the 2015–2024 study window was reunification, rather than whether the child ever reunified at any point in the data.

The secondary outcome is re-entry after reunification. Re-entry was constructed among children who were observed to reunify at least once during the study period. A child was coded as having re-entered if they had a reunification discharge and then appeared again in a later AFCARS year. This creates a binary measure of observed re-entry after reunification.

This measure is intentionally narrower than a complete lifetime measure of re-entry. Because the data only cover 2015–2024, children who reunified near the end of the observation window had limited opportunity to be observed re-entering foster care. To reduce this problem, children whose first observed reunification occurred in the final observed year were excluded from the re-entry construction. The re-entry variable should therefore be described as observed re-entry within the study window, not as a complete measure of whether a child ever re-entered foster care after reunification.

Key Independent Variables:

Race and ethnicity are measured using AFCARS child race and ethnicity variables. The AFCARS file includes separate indicators for American Indian or Alaska Native, Asian, Black or African American, Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islander, White, unable to determine, and Hispanic or Latino ethnicity. In the analysis, race/ethnicity is treated as a categorical variable. White children are used as the reference group in regression models. The purpose of including race is not to treat race as a biological cause of foster care outcomes, but to examine how racialized patterns appear within child welfare processes.

Placement instability is the central explanatory pathway in this project. AFCARS includes the number of placement settings in the data. This is the number of places the child has lived, including the current setting, during the current removal episode. In this study, placement instability was measured using the maximum observed number of placement settings across the child's AFCARS records. This maximum value was then recoded into four categories: 1 placement, 2–3 placements, 4–5 placements, and 6 or more placements. The one-placement group is used as the reference category in the regression models.

Region was included as a geographic control to account for broad place-based differences in foster care systems while avoiding the multicollinearity issues that appeared in preliminary models with more detailed state-level controls. State information was grouped into four broad regions: Northeast, Central, South, and West. In the regression models, the Northeast was used as the reference category, meaning that the estimated odds ratios for Central, South, and West compare each region to the Northeast. This grouping helps adjust for large geographic differences in reunification patterns without requiring a separate coefficient for each state. However, this measurement choice necessarily reduces state-level detail. Because reunification varies meaningfully across states even within the same region, region is best understood as a broad geographic control rather than a substitute for a full state-level policy analysis.

Age at removal was included as a continuous predictor. This matters because children who enter foster care at different ages may face different permanency timelines, placement experiences, case goals, and reunification possibilities. Its odds ratio should be interpreted as the change in the odds of reunification associated with a one-year increase in age at removal, holding the other model variables constant. Including age helps separate the effect of placement instability and race from basic age differences in the foster care population.

Sex was included as a child-level demographic control. In the regression models, sex was treated as a categorical variable. Male children are used as the reference group. Including sex helps adjust for basic demographic differences across children in the dataset.

Disability was measured as a binary indicator. This was coded as the child being recorded as having any of the following indicators in any observed year: clinically diagnosed disability, emotional disturbance, other medically diagnosed condition requiring special care, intellectual

disability, visual or hearing impairment, or physical disability. The comparison group is children with no recorded disability indicator in the selected AFCARS disability measures. Therefore, the disability odds ratio compares children with at least one recorded disability-related indicator to children without any of those recorded indicators, holding the other model variables constant.

Abuse was measured as a binary predictor using AFCARS removal reason variables. A child was coded as having an abuse-related removal history if physical abuse, sexual abuse, or neglect was recorded as a removal reason in any observed year. The comparison group is children with no recorded physical abuse, sexual abuse, or neglect removal reason. Therefore, the abuse odds ratio compares children with any recorded abuse or neglect removal reason to children without those recorded removal reasons, holding the other model variables constant.

Other parental barriers were measured using AFCARS removal reason variables related to parent or caretaker circumstances. It was treated as a binary predictor of whether any of the following were recorded in any observed year: parent alcohol abuse, parent drug abuse, parent death, parent incarceration, caretaker inability to cope, or abandonment. The comparison group is children with no recorded parental barrier or related removal circumstance in those selected variables. Therefore, the parental barrier odds ratio compares children with at least one recorded parental barrier to children without any of those recorded barriers, holding the other model variables constant.

Racial matching was included as a supplementary measure rather than as a primary predictor in the main reunification model. This measure compares the child's race to the recorded race of the first and second foster caregivers. A binary version of the variable identifies whether the child matched at least one recorded foster caregiver, while a ternary version distinguishes

between children who matched neither caregiver, one caregiver, or both caregivers. In the models using the binary racial matching measure, children with no recorded caregiver racial match served as the comparison group. In the ternary version, children who matched neither caregiver served as the comparison group. This measure should be interpreted cautiously because caregiver race information was missing for a substantial share of cases. In exploratory checks, caregiver race was missing for 43.6% of cases overall. Because of this missingness, racial matching is treated as an exploratory extension of the analysis rather than as one of the central findings. The results from these models are therefore used to suggest possible patterns, not to make strong claims about the independent effect of racial matching on reunification or placement stability.

Measurement Choices:

Several measurement choices were necessary because AFCARS is organized as annual administrative data, while this project analyzes children across a decade. The first major choice was to flatten the data from repeated annual records into one child-level record. This allowed the analysis to avoid counting the same child multiple times while still preserving information from multiple years.

Different types of variables were collapsed differently. Demographic variables that should be relatively stable, such as sex and race/ethnicity, were generally measured using the most recent non-missing value. Event-based variables, such as disability indicators, abuse removal reasons, and parental barrier removal reasons, were measured as “ever observed” indicators because they may appear in one year but still describe an important part of the child’s case history. Placement count was measured using the maximum observed number of

placements, because the highest observed placement count best captures the child's greatest level of placement instability during the study window. The code also retained detailed component variables for later interpretation, including specific disability, abuse, parental barrier, payment, and placement-related indicators.

The second major choice was how to define reunification. Rather than coding children as reunified if they ever reunified, the primary outcome uses the final observed discharge outcome. This makes the outcome easier to interpret as the child's final observed permanency status within the study window. The project also uses re-entry after reunification to address the fact that reunification is not always permanent. Together, these two outcomes allow the study to ask both whether children reunify and whether reunification appears stable afterward.

The third major choice was to categorize placement stability rather than use the raw placement count alone. The categories of one, two to three, four to five, and six or more placements make the results more interpretable and allow the analysis to compare children with increasingly unstable placement histories.

Analytic Strategy:

The primary analytic strategy is logistic regression. Logistic regression is appropriate because the main outcome, reunification, is binary. The models estimate the adjusted odds that a child reunified rather than having another observed final discharge outcome. Results are interpreted using odds ratios. Odds ratios above one indicate higher odds of reunification relative to the reference group, while odds ratios below one indicate lower odds of reunification.

The main reunification model includes race/ethnicity, placement instability, region, age at removal, sex, disability, abuse history, and parental barriers. The main purpose is to estimate whether placement instability remains associated with reunification after adjusting for demographic and case characteristics.

To examine placement instability as a possible pathway, the analysis compares models before and after adding placement instability. The first model estimates racial differences in reunification while controlling for other child and case characteristics. The second model adds placement instability. If racial differences shrink after placement instability is included, that pattern suggests that placement instability may explain part of the relationship between race and reunification. This does not prove causality, but it does provide evidence consistent with the argument that instability is an upstream process shaping permanency outcomes.

A secondary logistic regression model examines re-entry after reunification. This model is restricted to children who were observed to reunify. The outcome is whether the child later appeared in AFCARS after reunification, indicating observed re-entry into foster care. This model uses the same basic predictors as the reunification model, allowing the project to compare predictors of reunification with predictors of re-entry.

Racial matching analyses are supplemental. These analyses examine whether children whose race matches at least one recorded caregiver differ in placement instability or reunification. Because caregiver race is missing for many children, these results are not treated as the central evidence of the paper.

Limitations:

This study has several limitations. First, AFCARS is administrative data, meaning the analysis depends on how states record and report information. The data provide broad national coverage, but reporting practices may differ by state and year. Some variables may be missing, inconsistently recorded, or affected by changes in AFCARS reporting rules.

Second, the data cover only the 2015–2024 observation window. Children may have foster care experiences before or after this period that are not captured here. This matters most for re-entry metrics. A child who reunified in 2023 or 2024 may re-enter foster care after the data window ends, but this study would not observe that later event. For this reason, re-entry is measured as observed re-entry within the study window, not lifetime re-entry.

Third, the child-level flattening process simplifies complex foster care trajectories. Reducing multiple annual records into one row per child makes the analysis possible, but it also means that timing is not modeled as precisely as it would be in a full event-history or survival analysis. For example, the maximum number of placements captures the highest observed level of instability, but it does not fully distinguish when those placements occurred or how quickly they happened.

Fourth, the analysis is observational. Logistic regression can show whether race, placement instability, region, age, disability, abuse, and parental barriers are associated with reunification, but it cannot prove that any one factor caused reunification or prevented it. Placement instability may partly explain racial differences in reunification, but the analysis cannot fully rule out unmeasured factors such as county/state level practices, availability of kinship placements, court timelines, parental service access, or caseworker decision-making.

Finally, racial matching is limited by missing caregiver race information. Because caregiver race is not observed for a large share of cases and appears to be missing unevenly across reunification outcomes, racial matching results should be interpreted cautiously. That is why racial matching is framed as an exploratory extension rather than a primary conclusion.

Findings:

The findings show that reunification varies across geography, placement history, race and ethnicity, and case characteristics. Across the models, placement instability is the most consistent predictor of reunification. Children with more placements are less likely to reunify, and placement instability also helps explain part of the racial pattern in reunification outcomes. The re-entry results add an important complication by showing how “fair” certain predictors are.

State-Level Variation:

The descriptive results show that reunification varies substantially by state. This matters because foster care is administered through state and local systems, meaning that children’s permanency outcomes may be shaped not only by their case characteristics but also by the institutional context in which their case occurs.

Reunification rates vary across states

State-level final reunification rates across the AFCARS sample.

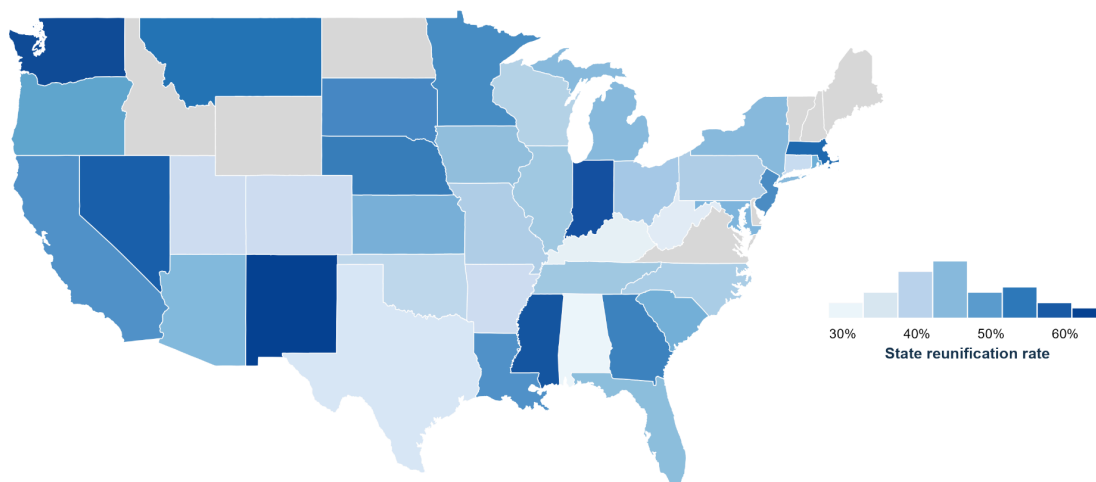


Figure 1. State-level reunification rates across the AFCARS sample. Darker blue states had higher final observed reunification rates, while lighter states had lower rates. Gray states had too small of a sample to be included in the model.

Figure 1 shows that reunification rates are not evenly distributed across the country. Some states are around the low 30% range, while others exceed 60%. This spread suggests that reunification is partly shaped by geographically dependent systems, including agency practices, service availability, court timelines, and policy environments. Because the map shows meaningful geographic variation, the adjusted models include region as a broad control. However, regions should be interpreted cautiously because states within the same region still differ from one another (particularly Mississippi, Alabama, and Georgia show significant within-region variation).

Placement Stability:

The strongest descriptive pattern is the relationship between placement instability and reunification. Children with fewer placements were much more likely to reunify than children who experienced repeated placement moves. This pattern appears before any statistical adjustment and gives an initial view of why placement stability is central to the analysis.

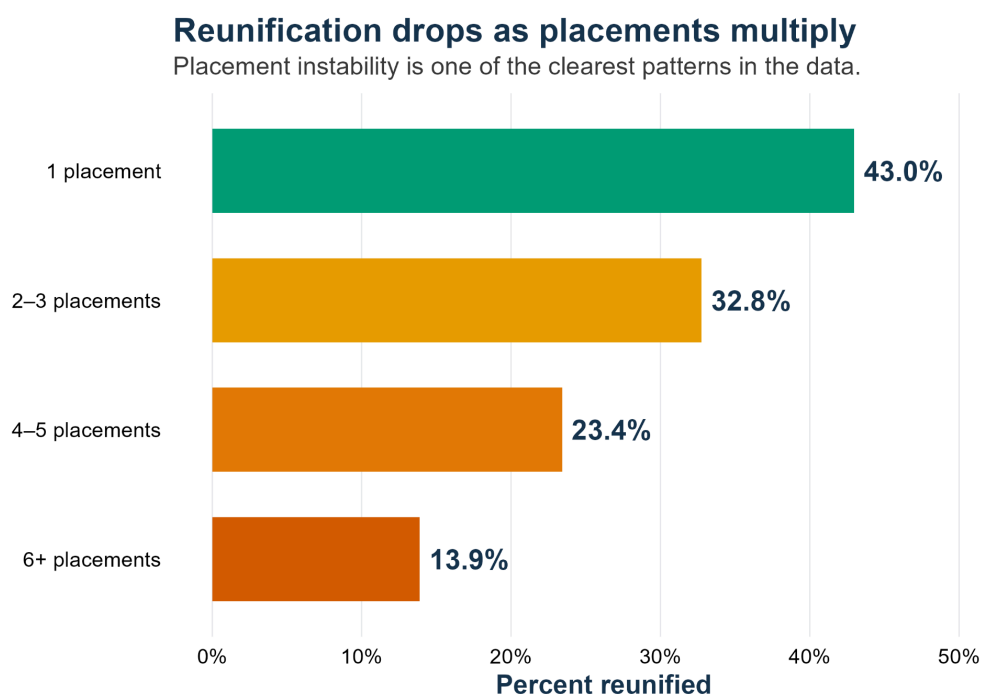


Figure 2. Reunification rates by number of placements. Reunification rates decline steadily as placement counts increase.

Figure 2 shows a clear stepwise decline. Children with one placement had a reunification rate of 43.0%, compared to 32.8% for children with two to three placements, 23.4% for children with four to five placements, and 13.9% for children with six or more placements. This means children with six or more placements reunified at less than one-third the rate of children with only one placement. The decline is not limited to the most unstable cases: even the move from one placement to two or three placements is associated with a noticeable drop in reunification.

Repeated moves may disrupt relationships with caregivers, schools, caseworkers, siblings, and biological families. Placement instability may also reflect more complex cases or weaker institutional support. The descriptive results show that children's lack of (even temporary) permanency while in care is closely connected to their eventual permanency outcomes.

Adjusted Predictors of Reunification:

The descriptive pattern remains visible in the adjusted logistic regression model. The model estimates the odds of reunification while controlling for race/ethnicity, region, placement instability, sex, age at removal, disability, abuse history, and parental barriers. Odds ratios below one indicate lower odds of reunification compared to the reference group, while odds ratios above one indicate higher odds.

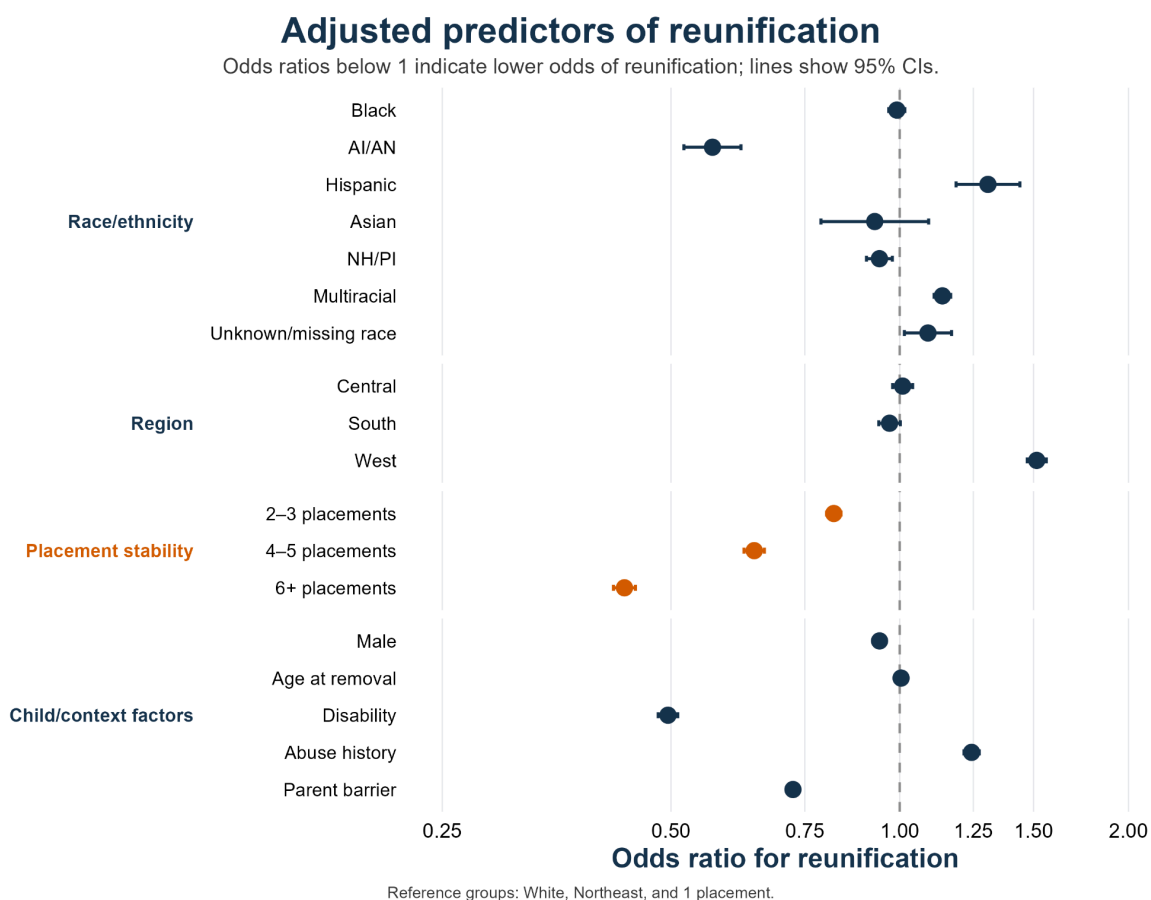


Figure 3. Adjusted predictors of reunification. Points show adjusted odds ratios from the logistic regression model. Lines show 95% confidence intervals.

Figure 3 shows that placement instability remains one of the strongest predictors of reunification after adjustment. Compared to children with one placement, children with two to three placements, four to five placements, and six or more placements all had lower adjusted odds of reunification. The pattern is graded, meaning that the odds decline as the number of placements increases.

Other predictors also matter. Children with a recorded disability indicator had lower adjusted odds of reunification, as did children with recorded parental barriers. These findings suggest that disability-related needs and parental circumstances may make reunification more

difficult. Oddly, abuse history was associated with higher adjusted odds of reunification. This is counterintuitive and warrants future research.

Racial and ethnic differences remain visible in the adjusted model, though the pattern is not uniform. American Indian/Alaska Native children had lower adjusted odds of reunification compared to White children, while Hispanic children had higher adjusted odds. Hispanic children's higher odds of reunification are less explained by placement stability than disparities observed for other groups, which points toward cultural or relational dynamics that the AFCARS data cannot directly capture. One candidate is *familismo*. This is a documented orientation toward family loyalty, obligation, and collective responsibility in Latino communities. If it strengthens biological family motivation and engagement through the reunification process, it may produce higher reunification rates even independent of placement experiences. Region also mattered, with the West showing higher odds of reunification compared to the Northeast. These results suggest that reunification is shaped by a combination of placement history, demographic patterns, family circumstances, and geographic context.

Does Accounting for Placement Stability Change Racial Differences?:

To examine whether placement instability helps explain racial differences in reunification, the analysis compared racial odds ratios before and after placement stability was added to the model. This comparison does not fully prove mediation in a causal sense, but it shows whether racial differences change once placement experiences are accounted for.

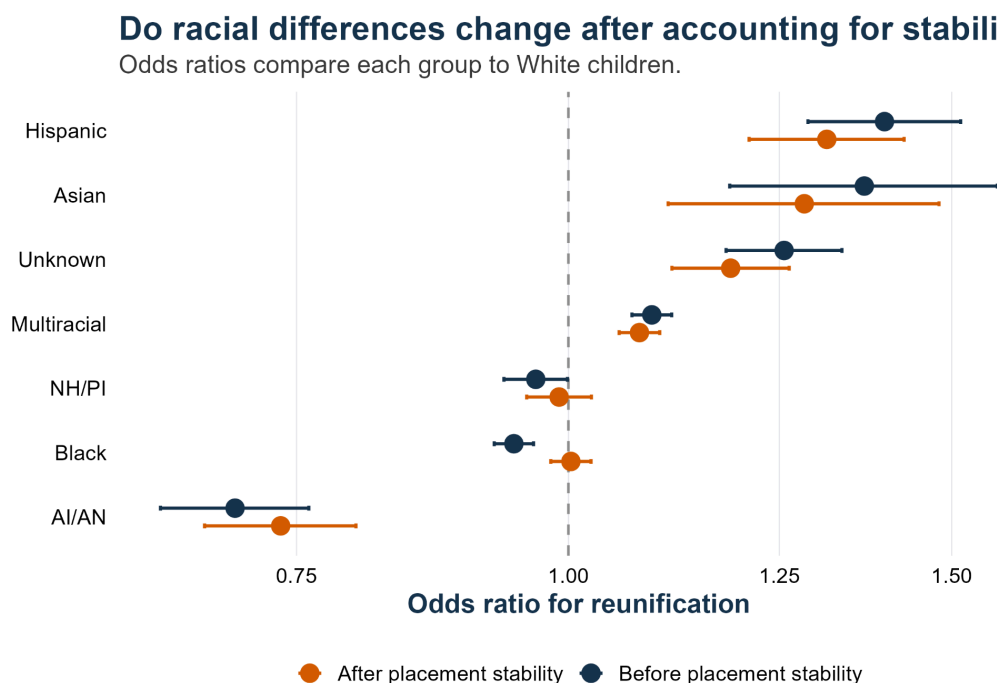


Figure 4. Racial differences in reunification before and after accounting for placement stability. Odds ratios compare each racial/ethnic group to White children. The orange estimates include placement stability in the model.

Figure 4 shows that accounting for placement stability attenuates some racial differences in reunification. For all groups, the odds ratio moves closer to 1 after placement stability is included. This suggests that placement instability may explain part of the racial pattern in reunification outcomes. Some observed racial differences may be connected to unequal placement experiences while children are in care. The clearest example is Black children. Before placement stability was added, Black children had lower odds of reunification than White children, with an odds ratio of 0.94. After placement stability was included, the odds ratio moved to 1.00, making the Black-White difference practically disappear in the adjusted model. This represents a 95.3% movement toward parity for Black children. Other groups also moved closer to parity, though to different degrees: NH/PI children moved 71.1% closer, Hispanic children

20.8%, Multiracial children 15.4%, and AI/AN children 11.7%. Overall, the pattern suggests that placement instability explains part, but not all, of the racial differences in reunification.

However, placement stability does not eliminate racial differences. American Indian/Alaska Native children continue to have lower odds of reunification compared to White children, and Hispanic children continue to have higher odds, even after accounting for placement stability. This means placement instability should be understood as a pathway and not the full explanation.

Re-entry After Reunification:

Re-entry after reunification provides a way to evaluate whether the predictors of reunification appear reasonable. If a factor is associated with lower odds of reunification and also higher odds of re-entry after reunification, then that pattern suggests the predictor may reflect real instability or risk. In other words, lower reunification odds may be more understandable when the same factor is also linked to a greater chance of returning to foster care. However, if a factor is associated with lower odds of reunification but not higher odds of re-entry, then the pattern is more concerning because it may suggest that some children are less likely to reunify even though they do not appear more likely to return to care afterward.

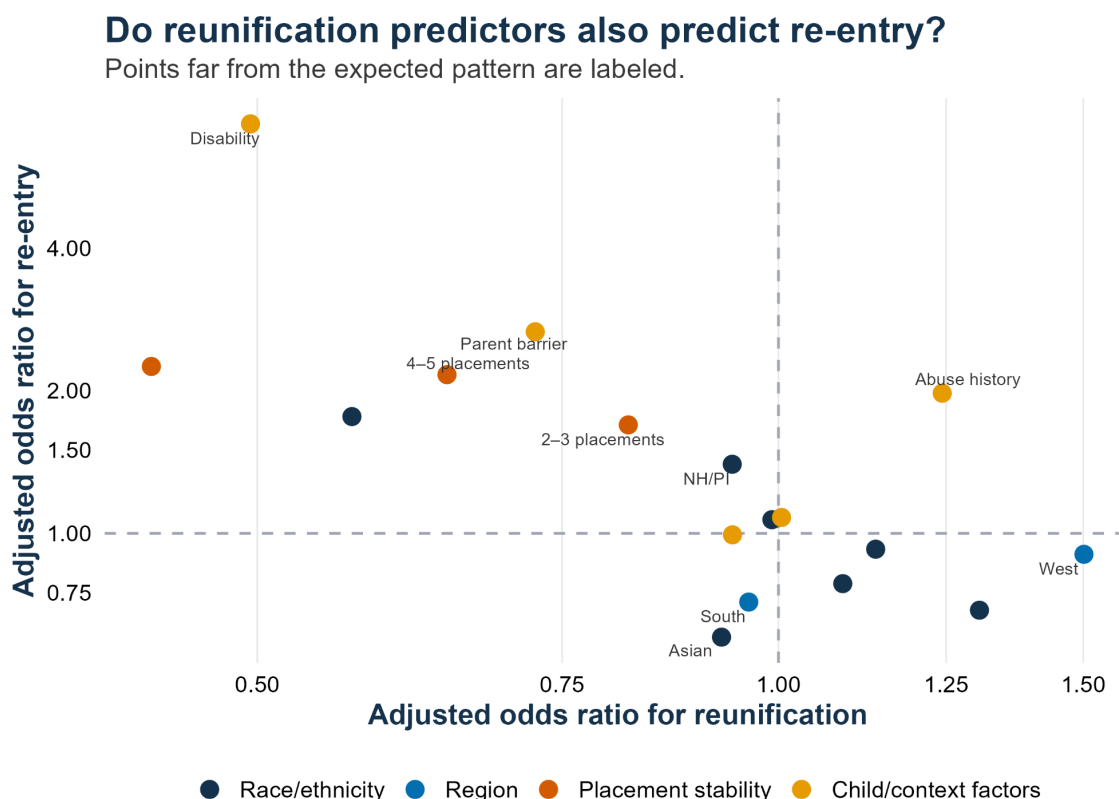


Figure 5. Adjusted predictors of reunification and re-entry after reunification. Points compare each predictor’s adjusted odds ratio for reunification with its adjusted odds ratio for re-entry after reunification. Dashed lines mark an odds ratio of 1.00, indicating no adjusted difference from the reference group. Labeled points identify predictors that deviate most from the expected reunification–re-entry relationship.

Figure 5 compares each predictor’s adjusted odds ratio for reunification with its adjusted odds ratio for re-entry after reunification. The dashed vertical and horizontal lines mark an odds ratio of 1.00. Points to the left of one on the x-axis are associated with lower odds of reunification, while points to the right are associated with higher odds of reunification. Points above one on the y-axis are associated with higher odds of re-entry, while points below one are associated with lower odds of re-entry.

The upper-left area of the plot is the clearest “risk-consistent” pattern: these predictors are associated with both lower odds of reunification and higher odds of re-entry. Disability, parental

barriers, and placement instability generally fall into this pattern. This means these factors are not only associated with children being less likely to reunify, but also with reunification being less stable when it does occur. In that sense, these predictors appear more substantively reasonable because lower reunification odds are paired with higher later re-entry risk.

Abuse history follows a different pattern. It is associated with both higher odds of reunification and higher odds of re-entry. The higher re-entry odds are substantively expected because abuse or neglect histories may reflect greater case risk. However, the higher reunification odds suggest that these cases may be reunifying at a relatively high rate despite their elevated likelihood of returning to care. This indicates, abuse history may intuitively contain a possible mismatch between high reunification likelihood and later stability.

The South region and Asian race categories show the clearest possible under-reunification pattern. Both have lower odds of reunification, but they also have lower odds of re-entry after reunification. In other words, these groups reunify less often, yet the reunifications that do occur appear more stable rather than less stable. If lower reunification odds were simply reflecting greater risk, we would expect higher re-entry odds afterward. Because that is not what appears in the data, these results raise concern that reunification may be occurring less often than expected for these groups relative to their observed re-entry outcomes.

Supplemental Racial Matching Analysis:

Finally, racial matching was examined as a supplemental analysis. These results are not treated as central findings because caregiver race information was missing for a substantial share of cases. However, the analysis is still useful because it provides an exploratory look at whether

the relationship between children and caregiver race is more closely related to placement stability or reunification.

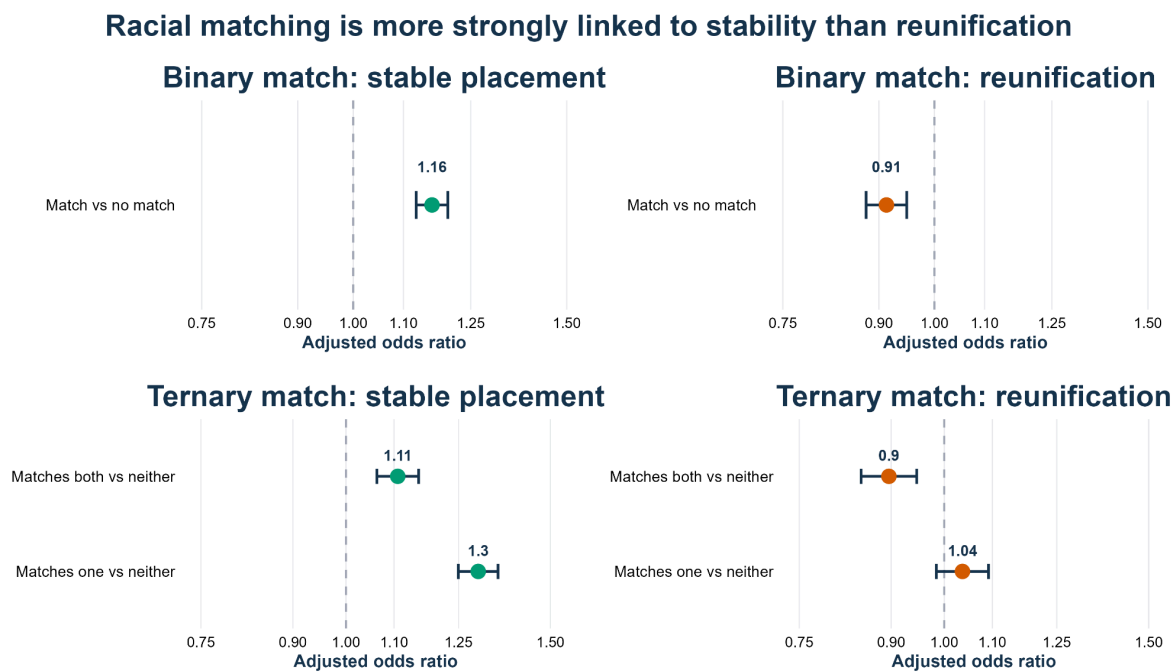


Figure 6. Racial matching, stable placement, and reunification. Stable placement is defined as fewer than four placements. Binary models compare children with a caregiver racial match to children with no match. Ternary models compare children who matched one or both caregivers to children who matched neither caregiver. Models adjust for all other predictors.

Figure 6 suggests that racial matching is more strongly related to placement stability than to reunification. This matches the direction suggested by prior literature: children whose race matched at least one recorded caregiver had higher adjusted odds of stable placement than children with no recorded match. In the binary model, the odds ratio for stable placement was 1.16, meaning that matched children had higher odds of having fewer than four placements. The ternary model shows a similar pattern. Children who matched one caregiver had especially higher odds of stable placement, with an odds ratio of 1.30, while children who matched both caregivers also had higher odds of stable placement, with an odds ratio of 1.11.

However, the reunification results do not line up with the stability results. Although racial matching is associated with higher placement stability, it is not associated with higher odds of reunification in the same way. In the binary model, children with a racial match had slightly lower adjusted odds of reunification, with an odds ratio of 0.91. In the ternary model, matching one caregiver resulted in an odds ratio of 1.04, while matching both caregivers was associated with lower odds of reunification, with an odds ratio of 0.90.

This distinction matters because placement stability and reunification are related but not identical outcomes. Racial matching may be associated with children experiencing fewer placement moves, but that does not necessarily mean those children are more likely to reunify. Because caregiver race information is missing for many cases, these results should be interpreted cautiously and treated as exploratory rather than central evidence.

Summary of Findings:

The findings show that reunification is shaped by geography, placement instability, race/ethnicity, and case context, but placement stability is the clearest and most consistent pattern. Children with more placements reunify at much lower rates, and this relationship remains strong after adjustment. Accounting for placement stability also reduces some racial differences, especially the Black-White gap, suggesting that unequal placement experiences help explain part of the racial pattern in reunification (acting as an upstream mediating factor). The re-entry analysis complicates the meaning of reunification by showing that some predictors, such as disability, parental barriers, and placement instability, are linked to both lower reunification and higher re-entry risk, while South and Asian categories may indicate possible under-reunification relative to observed stability. Finally, racial matching appears more closely

tied to placement stability than to reunification, making it useful as a supplemental finding but not a central conclusion.

Theoretical Implications:

The findings of this study are best explained through a structural risk perspective, with cumulative socioecological risk and life course theory helping explain the mechanisms through which instability shapes foster care outcomes. Reunification should be understood as the result of broader institutional processes and accumulated disadvantages.

The structural risk perspective provides the strongest overall explanation for the findings. Mills (1959) argued that the sociological imagination requires distinguishing between personal troubles, problems understood as failures of the individual, and public issues, which are rooted in the structure of institutions themselves. Repeated placement changes could easily be framed as a symptom of difficult family circumstances, but the datasets suggest otherwise. Placement stability predicted reunification outcomes even after adjusting for abuse history, parental barriers, disability, and demographics. What appears to be an individual case characteristic is partly a product of the structures of the foster care system. In child welfare research, Feely and Bosk (2021) apply this logic by arguing that disproportionality emerges from structural inequalities that shape family resources, surveillance, and access to support. This aligns closely with the findings because placement instability remained the clearest and most consistent predictor of reunification, even after adjusting for race, region, disability, abuse history, parental barriers, sex, and age at removal. Placement instability appears to reflect more than individual family circumstances. Repeated placement changes may also indicate broader institutional conditions,

including placement availability, agency practices, case complexity, and unequal access to support systems.

The findings also support the idea that placement instability may function as a pathway through which broader inequalities become connected to reunification outcomes. Racial differences in reunification became smaller after placement instability was added to the model, especially for Black children, whose adjusted odds moved nearly to parity with White children. This suggests that unequal placement experiences may help explain part of the racial pattern in reunification. However, because some racial differences remained even after accounting for instability, the results also suggest that placement instability is not the entire explanation for disparities within foster care outcomes.

Cumulative socioecological risk theory helps explain how these inequalities accumulate across multiple contexts. Using Bronfenbrenner's ecological systems theory and cumulative risk research (Bronfenbrenner, 1979; Rutter, 1979), this perspective argues that outcomes are shaped by overlapping disadvantages across the family, community, and institutional environment. This fits the results because predictors such as disability, parental barriers, and placement instability were associated with both lower reunification odds and higher re-entry risk. These patterns suggest that reunification outcomes are shaped by layered forms of instability rather than by one isolated factor.

Life course theory emphasizes how timing, transitions, and trajectories shape long-term outcomes (Elder, 1998). Foster care is not a single event, but a sequence of experiences that unfold across childhood. Placement changes may therefore function as turning points that disrupt relationships, schooling, and stability (Wulczyn, 2020). However, life course theory is limited in

this study because the datasets were flattened into one child-level record rather than analyzed as a full longitudinal trajectory model. While the findings support the importance of instability across time, the analysis cannot fully capture the sequencing or timing of placement experiences.

The findings suggest that structural risk provides the best explanation for reunification disparities, while cumulative socioecological risk and life course theory help explain how instability accumulates and affects permanency trajectories. Together, these frameworks show that reunification outcomes are shaped not only by individual family circumstances, but also by the institutional structure and instability of the foster care system itself.

Conclusion:

This study examined how race and placement instability shape reunification outcomes for children in foster care, and whether placement instability helps explain observed disparities in reunification. It also examined whether the same predictors associated with reunification were related to re-entry after reunification. Using AFCARS administrative data from 2015 through 2024, the analysis focused on reunification not simply as an outcome, but as part of a broader foster care process shaped by institutional instability, placement experiences, and demographic context.

The findings consistently showed that placement instability was the strongest predictor of reunification. Children who experienced repeated placement changes had substantially lower odds of reunifying, even after adjusting for race/ethnicity, region, age, sex, disability, abuse history, and parental barriers. The relationship was also graded, with reunification odds declining as placement counts increased. This suggests that placement instability is not simply a

background characteristic of foster care, but a central part of how permanency outcomes develop.

The results also showed that accounting for placement instability reduced some racial differences in reunification, especially for Black children. This supports the argument that unequal placement experiences help explain part of the racial pattern in reunification outcomes. It shows how placement stability can be seen as an upstream factor that mediates disparities. However, placement instability did not fully eliminate racial differences, particularly for American Indian/Alaska Native children and Hispanic children, suggesting that additional institutional and contextual factors likely contribute to disparities within foster care systems.

The re-entry analysis complicated the interpretation of reunification by showing that lower reunification odds do not always correspond to higher re-entry risk. Predictors such as disability, parental barriers, and placement instability were associated with both lower reunification and higher re-entry, suggesting that these factors reflect genuine instability or long-term case difficulty. However, some groups, particularly children in the South region and Asian children, showed lower reunification odds despite lower re-entry odds.

This project contributes to the foster care literature by examining placement instability as a possible pathway connecting race, institutional context, and permanency outcomes. Existing literature identifies predictors of reunification separately. This study examined how those predictors operate together within the foster care process itself. Methodologically, the project also contributes by using approximately 2.6 million child records across a ten-year period, allowing for a broader national analysis of reunification and re-entry patterns than many prior studies.

Several limitations should be acknowledged. AFCARS is administrative data, meaning the analysis depends on how states recorded and reported information. Reporting practices vary across states and years, and some variables contain substantial missingness. The study window also only covers 2015 through 2024, meaning some children may have re-entered foster care after the observation period ended. In addition, flattening the data into one child-level record simplifies complex foster care trajectories and limits the ability to model timing or sequencing directly. Most importantly, the analysis is observational and cannot fully establish causal relationships. Placement instability may help explain reunification disparities, but the models cannot fully account for unobserved factors such as county-level practices, service access, court processes, or caseworker decision-making.

Future research should examine how specific state and county-level policies shape placement instability and reunification outcomes. Because the descriptive findings showed substantial geographic variation, more detailed policy-focused analyses may help explain why some foster care systems produce more stable outcomes than others. Future work could also use interviews with foster youth, biological families, foster parents, and caseworkers to better understand the mechanisms behind racial differences and placement instability. Additionally, event-history approaches could model the timing and sequencing of placements more directly, allowing researchers to better understand how instability accumulates over time and affects permanency trajectories.

The findings suggest that reunification outcomes are shaped not only by family circumstances, but also by the structure and stability of the foster care system itself. Children who experience repeated instability while in care are substantially less likely to achieve stable

permanency outcomes. Permanency is supposed to be what foster care works toward, but for children experiencing repeated placement changes, the system itself becomes the obstacle.

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